Line breaking

A paragraph is broken into lines by considering every feasible break at once and choosing the sequence whose total demerits are smallest. The method looks ahead to the end of the paragraph, so an awkward break near the bottom can change the very first line, which is why justified text set this way has an unusually even colour across the page.

Hyphenation

Hyphenation helps the optimiser when a long word would otherwise leave a loose line. Typographers generally prefer no more than two consecutive hyphenated lines, never a hyphen on the last full line of a page, and never a word broken after a single letter; the parameters reproduce those conventions numerically rather than by inspection.

Spacing

Interword spaces stretch and shrink within limits taken from the font. After a full stop, question mark or exclamation mark the space is a little wider, except after abbreviations such as e.g. or after a capital initial, where an ordinary space keeps the reading rhythm intact.